

TEAM MODI The PM with BJP president J.P. Nadda and Union ministers Amit Shah and Rajnath Singh, Dec. 3

WHAT THE THREE WINS HAVE DONE FOR THE BJP IS TO DROWN THE CRESCENDO THAT HAD BEGUN BUILDING AROUND THE OPPOSITION'S DEMAND FOR A CASTE CENSUS AND PROPORTIONATE OBC QUOTAS

have highlighted," says political strategist and analyst Amitabh Tiwari, "is that the Congress will not be able to beat the BJP in states where it is in a one-on-one contest with it." Its track record in such states is evidence enough. In seven states where the BJP is its prime rival—Himachal Pradesh, Uttarakhand, Chhattisgarh, Rajasthan, Gujarat, MP and Karnataka—the Congress won only four of the 128 Lok Sabha seats in 2019. Given Modi's high popularity ratings and his ability to sway voters decisively, as the triple wins in the north have demonstrated, experts expect the 2024 results to be no different in these seven states. Even in Karnataka and Himachal, where the Congress is in power, opinion polls show Modi as the preferred choice at the Centre.

The Congress decimation in the north (it now has only Himachal) is also likely to have a deleterious effect on Opposition unity under the aegis of INDIA. Tiwari feels that the Congress may have made a mistake in brushing off seat-sharing requests from alliance partners, particularly from the Samajwadi Party, in these states. Its dismal performance also puts the party at a disadvantage within the alliance, strengthening the belief in some quarters that if the Congress cannot defeat the BJP in its own bastions, it cannot help other allies counter the saffron challenge in their respective states. Both Nitish Kumar of the Janata Dal (United) and Mamata Banerjee of the Trinamool Congress, who had ceded senior partner rights to the Congress, may now look to lead the alliance themselves. The BJP's strong showing could also see smaller parties in INDIA dump the alliance and gravitate towards the ruling dispensation at the Centre. Neutral states, too, may shy from taking on BJP aggressively.

BIG GAINS FOR THE BJP

What its triple victory has helped the BJP do is drown the crescendo that had started building around the caste census and OBC reservations. With Nitish the first to unbottle that genie, the Congress was quick to latch on to its potential and pitch Mandal 2.0 as the lead narrative of the Opposition campaign going into 2024. The limits of this plank stood exposed in the recent elections, with the OBCs voting massively in favour of the BJP in the three northern states. Modi's emphasis on directing his welfare schemes to a broad spectrum of socio-economic groups and laser focus on performance and delivery seem to have transcended caste considerations among voters. He put it pithily enough, "I cater to only four castes—women, youth, the farmers and the poor." Says political analyst Rajat Sethi, "The entire OBC census drive had the BJP worried. But with these results, the BJP can breathe much easier, as it does not seem to have made a dent in its vote banks or given the Opposition any advantage." The Modi government was even contemplating the implementation of the Justice Rohini Committee report on OBC sub-categorisation to neutralise Opposition calls for a national OBC census, but now it can take its time over it.

The BJP heaved another sigh of relief when issues such as the restoration of the Old Pension Scheme (OPS), which the Congress was pushing hard for, did not get the expected traction. Earlier, worried by its impact, the Union finance ministry had constituted a committee under finance secretary T.V. Somanathan to review OPS and home minister Shah had committed to holding a discussion once the panel submitted its report. Its electoral victories will now ease the pressure on the Modi government to address the vexatious issue with any sense of urgency.

The triad of wins has certainly put Modi and the BJP in pole position to race ahead for a third term at the Centre. But it is not a done deal. The first sign of warning came in